Lesson 34: Reading Academic Articles and Writing an Annotated Bibliography

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 4: Research and Evidence

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 3.8 Reading Academic Articles for Research; 3.9 Writing an Annotated Bibliography; 3.10 Language Toolkit; 3.11 Takeaways.

In this lesson

You learn how academic and popular sources differ, what the parts of a journal article are, and how fast to read each part, using an article that Lily used. Then you study Lily's annotated bibliography and write one for your project. These skills save time and help you plan a paper.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Distinguish academic and popular sources.
- Name the parts of a journal article and decide how carefully to read each one.
- Write annotated bibliography entries with a citation, a summary and an evaluation.
- Ask for research help clearly and politely.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
academic (scholarly) source	contains original research; written by experts for other academic readers	Han and Onchwari's journal article
popular source	a newspaper or magazine article for a general audience	the EdSource article by Peele and Willis
credentials	qualifications that show expertise	Insoon Han, PhD
abstract	a short summary at the start of an article	"This paper describes a mentoring program ..."
literature review	the part of an article that reports what others have already written	"What have others already said about my topic?"
annotated bibliography	a list of sources (entries), each with a full citation and notes (an annotation): summary and evaluation	Lily's annotated bibliography
working thesis	a first thesis that may change as you research	Although minority faculty members play an important role ...

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
reporting verb	a verb that introduces what a source says	explain, claim, suggest, state, report
This source seems credible because ...	an evaluation frame	... Han and Onchwari are professors of education.
I was wondering if you could assist me with ...	a polite request	... with evaluating my sources.

Rules and explanations

Academic and popular sources (Table 3.8.1)

Feature	Academic	Popular
Content	original research data, such as scientific studies	popular-interest topics, or summaries of research done by others
Authors	expert scholars, with credentials listed	often journalists or writers
Readers	scholars, researchers	general public
Purpose	to share research findings and expand knowledge	to inform or entertain
Style	straightforward design, complex language	flashy design, accessible language
Citations and review	citations; peer-reviewed	few or no citations; not peer-reviewed

Both are useful: academic sources give specific, researched facts; popular sources give current news, opinions and examples.

Parts of a journal article and how to read them (Table 3.8.2)

The lesson material lists the usual sections and what each contains: Title, Author Information, Abstract, Introduction or Background, Methods, Results, Discussion, Conclusion, References. Not every article has every section. You do not need to read everything slowly:

How to read	Parts
carefully	Title, Abstract, Background or Literature Review, Discussion, Conclusion
somewhat carefully	Introduction
quickly	Authors (good credentials?)
very quickly	Methods, Results (mostly for other researchers), References (anything else to read?)

Do not cite from the abstract: find the relevant part of the article and cite that.

The annotated bibliography (3.9)

- It helps you organize sources before you write and think critically about how reliable and useful they are.
- Each entry has a **complete citation** and one paragraph with a **summary** and an **evaluation**. Lily also puts her working thesis at the top.
- **Summary:** the first sentence gives the author's name + a reporting verb, the main idea, and the type of source. Frames: *In this [type of source], [author's name] explains [main idea]. / According to [author's name] in this [type of source], [main idea]. / [Author's name] claims in this [type of source] that [main idea].*
- **Evaluation:** How credible is the source? Are there biases? Why is it relevant to your topic? How will you use it? Frames: *This source seems credible because ... / This source may be considered biased because ... / The research strongly supports my research question because ... / I plan to use this in the [introduction/background/cause/effect, etc.] section of my paper to show ...*

Asking for help (3.10)

Use a sentence starter + a gerund (Table 3.10.2): *I need some help with / I am having trouble with / I was wondering if you could assist me with + narrowing down my topic, finding key word synonyms, citing this information correctly ...* Also say what you have already done. Your tutor can play the librarian.

> **Psychology note:** In APA style, the list is called References and each entry gives the year after the authors. Han and Onchwari's article in APA: Han, I., & Onchwari, J. A. (2018). Development and implementation of a culturally responsive mentoring program for faculty and staff of color. *Interdisciplinary Journal of Partnership Studies, 5*(2), Article 3. https://doi.org/10.24926/ijps.v5i2.1006 (The book's MLA citation, like the journal's web page, gives the second author's initials as "A. J."; the article itself names her Jacqueline Ariri Onchwari, so use "J. A.")
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> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic script has no capital letters, so capitals in titles are easy to forget. MLA capitalizes the main words of every title ("Maintaining Heritage Language: Perspectives of Korean Parents"). In APA article titles, capitalize only the first word, the first word after a colon, and names; in journal names, capitalize the main words.

Practice

Exercise 1. Academic or popular? Use Table 3.8.1. Decide and give two reasons.

1. Han and Onchwari, "Development and Implementation of a Culturally Responsive Mentoring Program for Faculty and Staff of Color", *Interdisciplinary Journal of Partnership Studies*
2. Peele and Willis, "California's Failure to Diversify Community College Faculty Tied to Arcane State Law", *EdSource*
3. Kazembe, "I Prepare Aspiring Teachers to Educate Kids of Color", *The Conversation* (Lesson 31)

Exercise 2. Parts of an article. Use the list and Table 3.8.2.

1. Which part describes how the study was performed?

2. Which part presents the results without interpretation?
3. Which part interprets the results and never presents new data?
4. Which part is a short summary that shares the findings?
5. Which part lists all the works cited?

Exercise 3. Let's try a real article (3.8). The book's video is no longer online, so read Han and Onchwari's article yourself with Table 3.8.2 (your tutor has the text; it is also free online).

1. What are the authors' credentials and jobs?
2. According to the abstract, what does the paper describe, and who are its recommendations for?
3. Which usual parts (Methods, Results, Discussion) does the article not have? Why? (Read "Assessing the Impact and Looking to the Future".)
4. In the Background, what percentage of employees in US higher education are employees of color?
5. How does the article define "cultural taxation"?
6. In which section is the sentence Lily quotes, "the significance of nurturing and sustaining productive and fulfilled employees of color cannot be overstated"? Is it a good section to cite from?

Exercise 4. Reading Lily's annotated bibliography (3.9).

1. Which entry begins with a frame like each of these? a. In this [type of source], [author's name] explains … b. According to [author's name] in this [type of source], … c. [Author's name] claims in this [type of source] that …
2. In the Han and Onchwari entry, what reasons does Lily give for credibility, and how will she use the source?
3. Which strategies does Lily use to evaluate her sources?
4. Compare the annotated bibliography with her final essay (Lesson 31). Which sources did she use, and which not? Which essay sources are not in the annotated bibliography? Why might this be?
5. Does she have enough sources? Which seem strongest?
6. Lily describes Barbara J. Johnson as a Harvard professor of English and Comparative Literature and of Law and Psychiatry. What should a careful researcher check?

Exercise 5. Summary sentences. Write the first sentence of an annotation for Han and Onchwari's article three times, once with each summary frame.

Exercise 6. Notice this! A request for help (3.10). Read Lily's email to Ms. Yap. What makes it effective? Find two small language errors in her last sentence.

Speak with your tutor

- "Act as a librarian. Here is my email asking for help: [paste]. Answer it, then tell me how to make it clearer."
- "Here is the abstract of an article I found: [paste]. Is it academic or popular? Which sections should I read carefully for my research question?"

- "Ask me the reflection questions from 3.11 one by one: how I research in everyday life, my research path, my biggest challenges, and how my thinking changed."
- "Here is one entry of my annotated bibliography: [paste]. Does the first sentence have the author, a reporting verb, the type of source and the main idea? Is my evaluation specific?"

Read aloud

Stressed syllables are in CAPITALS. Pause briefly at each /.

1. An annotated bib·li·OG·ra·phy / is a list of sources / with a summary and an evaluation of each.
2. In their academic article, / Han and Onchwari describe a mentoring program / that was set up to support faculty of color / at a university that is mostly white.
3. This is a credible article / because Han and Onchwari are professors of education.
4. I was wondering if you could assist me / with evaluating my sources.

Writing task

Write an annotated bibliography for your research project from Lessons 32 and 33 (for example, sleep and memory in university students).

- At the top: your name and your working thesis (or your research question).
- Three to five sources, at least two of them scholarly journal articles, in alphabetical order.
- Each entry: a complete citation (MLA as in the book, or APA for psychology), then a paragraph of 100 to 150 words with a summary and an evaluation (credibility, bias, relevance, planned use).

Self-editing checklist:

- Is every citation complete (author, title, publication, date, pages or DOI) and correctly capitalized?
- Does each summary begin with the author, a reporting verb, the type of source and the main idea?
- Did I summarize in my own words, with any exact words in quotation marks?
- Did I explain why each source is credible (or what its limits are)?
- Did I say how each source relates to my research question and where I will use it?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Han and Onchwari's article, free online (the video in 3.8 is no longer available): https://pubs.lib.umn.edu/index.php/ijps/article/view/1006

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. Academic: the authors are scholars with credentials (PhD, EdD; education professors); it is in an academic journal; it has many citations and a reference list.
2. Popular: education journalism for a general audience; it reports statistics and quotes people instead of presenting original research.
3. Popular: written for the general public in accessible language, summarizes research done by others, and is not peer-reviewed, although the author is a professor and links to research.

Exercise 2

1. Methods (Methodology). 2. Results. 3. Discussion. 4. Abstract (the Conclusion also summarizes the findings, but it comes at the end and adds their significance). 5. References (also called Bibliography, Works Cited or Literature Cited).

Exercise 3

1. Insoon Han, PhD (Assistant Professor) and Jacqueline Ariri Onchwari, EdD (Associate Professor), Education Department, University of Minnesota Duluth. They started and ran the program, so they know it well, but they describe their own work.
2. A culturally responsive mentoring program for university employees of color and American Indians (history, goals, components, outcomes, plans). The recommendations are for individuals, researchers and administrators who might adopt a similar program.
3. It has none of these three sections: it describes a program instead of reporting a study; the survey results "will be reported in another paper". Its main sections are Introduction, Background, the program, Assessing the Impact and Looking to the Future, and Implications and Conclusion.
4. Only 17% (Turner et al., 2008), compared with nearly 50% of the general population.
5. "the extra burden of service responsibilities placed upon minority faculty members because of their racial or ethnic background" (the problem Lily describes in her essay).
6. In the Background section, on page 4 (Lily cites "(4)"). Yes: Table 3.8.2 says to read the background carefully and that you can cite it to support a point.

Exercise 4

1. a. Reid and Zalk ("In this encyclopedia article, Pamela Reid and Sue Zalk suggest ..."); also Han and Onchwari ("In their academic article, Han and Onchwari describe ..."). b. Valeri ("According to this reference article by Mauro Valeri, ..."). c. Johnson and Scafide ("Johnson and Scafide claim in this encyclopedia article that ..."); also Cleveland et al. ("Cleveland, et al. state in this encyclopedia article that ...").
2. Credibility: they are professors of education who have studied this problem on their own campus, and the article is in an academic journal. Use: in the background, to show that faculty of color are underrepresented but serve a very important role, and in the paragraphs on solutions, since mentoring seems very effective.

3. (example answer) The authors' backgrounds, the type of publication and publisher, the date, possible bias (Johnson and Scafide "seems unbiased"), relevance, and planned use. Some entries say little about the authors (Cleveland et al.; Peele and Willis).
4. Used: Cleveland et al., Han and Onchwari, Johnson and Scafide, Peele and Willis. Not used: Reid and Zalk, Valeri. Not in the annotated bibliography: Aguirre, Brayboy, Davis and Fry, Paganelli and Cangemi, Stout et al. Research is recursive: she kept searching, found new evidence, and dropped some plans (for example, imposter syndrome).
5. (example answer) Six is a good start, but only Han and Onchwari is a scholarly journal article; four are encyclopedia or dictionary articles and one is a news website. Han and Onchwari and Peele and Willis seem strongest: both are directly about faculty of color, and Peele and Willis is recent. Her final essay adds research articles (for example, Stout et al.).
6. Whether this is the same person: a professor of literature and law may not have written an education encyclopedia article on faculty diversity, and another researcher may have the same name. Search the author's name with the topic before you describe their credentials.

Exercise 5 (example answers)

- In this academic journal article, Han and Onchwari explain how a culturally responsive mentoring program supports faculty and staff of color at a mostly white university.
- According to Han and Onchwari in this journal article, a mentoring network run by and for employees of color gives its members a safe space and a sense of belonging.
- Han and Onchwari claim in this journal article that culturally responsive mentoring can improve the retention, recruitment and satisfaction of employees of color.

Exercise 6 Lily greets the librarian by name, says who she is and what her paper is about, explains what she has already done, names her exact problem, and asks politely and indirectly. Errors: "that I have best sources" should be "that I have **the** best sources"; and "I was wondering if you could assist me ..." is a statement (an indirect question), so it should end with a period, not a question mark.

My notes